Earthquake signals and Kilauea eruptions

A chronological machine-learning study of Pu'u O'o activity

Problem statement

Can the location, depth, magnitude, and recent rate of earthquakes in Kilauea's East Rift Zone help identify an ongoing Pu'u O'o eruptive episode or estimate the time to the next eruption? We reproduce these two tasks from the Stanford CS229 study by Mullet, Singh, and Wong, then evaluate later earthquakes with a time-ordered holdout.

Dataset and labels

The bundled catalogs contain 6,485 earthquake records and 49 eruption entries. Filtering to the East Rift Zone leaves 3,764 earthquakes; after a 30-day feature warm-up, the episode-48 coverage cutoff, and removal of records without a known next onset, 2,960 examples remain (304 eruptive, 10.3%). Features are longitude, latitude, depth, magnitude, and counts in the preceding 1, 7, and 30 days. Erupting labels use each catalog duration plus a 24-hour uncertainty buffer; time-to-eruption is measured in days.

Approach and implementation

We compare a prior/mean baseline, logistic regression, random forests, class-conditional K-means, and a small multilayer perceptron. Scaling is fit on training data. Hyperparameters are selected on development data, then evaluated once on the held-out test period. The chronological split uses 70% train, 20% development, and 10% test by time, a 30-day gap, and label-availability constraints. A random split is retained as a comparison. Code in src/data.py, src/models.py, and src/experiment.py writes the audit, metrics, predictions, and model bundles; demo.py predicts on a held-out earthquake.

Data quality decision

Episode 48 lists an implausible duration of 173,566,800 hours. We retain its onset as an exclusive cutoff and do not use the corrupted duration. The source also lists eruptions 35.5 and 35 out of order; preprocessing sorts onset-duration pairs together.

Results and conclusion

The chronological test period is the primary measure of future-period performance.

0.524	-0.012	7.75 d	-0.179
classification AUROC	Cohen's kappa	regression RMSE	regression R-squared

Held-out classification

Development selected class-conditional K-means (k=4). On the later test window, AUROC was 0.524, average precision 0.096, and kappa -0.012. It identified 12 of 19 eruptive examples (recall 0.632) while marking 194 repose examples as eruptive (precision 0.058). The score is near chance and produces many false alarms.

Held-out time-to-eruption regression

Development selected the mean baseline. It achieved RMSE 7.75 days, MAE 6.60 days, and R-squared -0.179. All tested regression families had negative test R-squared, so none explained more variation than a test-period mean reference. These data do not support useful time-to-eruption forecasts.

What the random split changes

A random test split gave the forest classifier AUROC 0.681 and kappa 0.166; its forest regression had RMSE 11.02 days and R-squared 0.159. Neighboring earthquakes can appear in both training and test sets under this split. The gap between protocols shows why the chronological result is the more relevant estimate for later-period use.

Conclusion

With seven catalog features and a small, imbalanced time series, these models do not forecast eruption timing reliably. The classification score has limited ranking power and low precision, while regression does not beat a mean reference by R-squared. Future work should test longer catalogs and independent signals such as ground deformation, gas emissions, and focal mechanisms. This is a classroom analysis, not an operational hazard tool.

Sources: Mullet, Singh, and Wong, “Predicting Eruptive Events at Volcanoes from Earthquake Data,” Stanford CS229, Fall 2019 (supplied PDF); source code and catalogs: github.com/bmullet/PEEVED. Results reproduced from the bundled CSV files with this project.